

# **Building a “Jiangxi Model” of Green Development Education and Consolidating the Foundation for Green Development**

## **Experience and Insights from Finland**

**Jiangxi University of Finance and Economics Think Tank Brief**

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Acknowledged by Mao Weiming, then Vice Governor of Jiangxi Province, with instructions to the Provincial Development and Reform Commission and the Provincial Department of Education to review the report and implement its recommendations as part of the province's efforts in the National Ecological Civilization Pilot Zone.

To the Leadership:

Jiangxi is fully implementing General Secretary Xi Jinping's key directives to build a “Jiangxi model” for a Beautiful China, as well as the major strategic initiatives of the CPC Central Committee concerning ecological civilization and green development and is actively exploring a “Jiangxi model” for ecological-civilization building and green development. Against this backdrop, building a “Jiangxi model” of green development education will not only help our province deepen implementation of the strategy of strengthening Jiangxi through education, but also help put into practice the province's six-part policy guideline—known in Chinese as the “24-character guideline”—of “innovation-led development, breakthroughs in reform, higher-standard opening-up, green development, taking responsibility and working hard, and revitalizing Jiangxi and enriching the people.” More importantly, it will help advance the grand blueprint of a prosperous, beautiful, happy, and modern Jiangxi, and deliver results that live up to the expectations to General Secretary Xi Jinping. We hereby submit this research report for your review.

**Council of the Jiangxi University of Finance and Economics Think Tank**

**June 12, 2019**

## Executive Summary

Jiangxi began relatively early in educating people in the idea of green development, and this has helped the province grow into a national pilot zone for ecological civilization, making it an ideal place to realize General Secretary Xi Jinping's vision of building a "Jiangxi model" for a Beautiful China. Yet Jiangxi has not established an education system oriented specifically toward green development. This report therefore recommends that the province learn from Finland's proven experience and, in light of the requirements of green development, formulate a plan for green development education in Jiangxi on the basis of the existing framework of education for sustainable development (ESD), establish a system of green development education, advance green development education from early childhood and initiate young children's understanding of green development, popularize green development education at the primary and secondary levels so that the concept takes root among adolescents, vigorously promote vocational education for green development so as to cultivate application-oriented talent suited to green development, and fully advance higher education for green development in order to meet the new needs of Jiangxi's green development and thereby form a distinct "Jiangxi model" of green development education.

## Introduction

The term "green development," as one of the five development concepts—'innovation, coordination, green development, openness, and sharing'—advanced in the context of socialism with Chinese characteristics entering a new era, is increasingly gaining recognition and acceptance worldwide. Since 2012, the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) has convened a regular annual forum on green growth and sustainable development. This indicates, to some extent, that the concept of "green development," is exerting a profound global influence. But how can the idea of green development be translated into concrete practice? Education must come first. In China, however, relevant work has been carried out mainly under the banner of education for sustainable development. From the China Agenda 21 issued in 1994 to the National Outline for Medium- and Long-Term Education Reform and Development (2010-2020) released in 2010, ESD has consistently been identified as one of the country's strategic themes. As early as 1996, China first proposed the concept of the "green school," and in 2013 it issued the Standards for the Evaluation of Green Campuses. In 2017, the report to the 19th National Congress of the Communist Party of China explicitly called for the advocacy of simple, moderate, green, and low-carbon lifestyles; opposition to extravagance, waste, and irrational consumption; and the launch of initiatives to create

conservation-oriented government institutions, green families, green schools, green communities, and green travel. In 2018, the National Development and Reform Commission issued the Work Plan for Initiatives to Create Conservation-Oriented Government Institutions, Green Families, Green Schools, Green Communities, and Green Travel, among other documents. In response, localities across the country also began exploring ways to bring the concept of green development into the classroom. Xining (China), for example, published and distributed a series of school-based teaching materials titled Xining Education: Green Development, with one volume each for lower primary, upper primary, junior secondary, and senior secondary students, centered on cultivating students' spirit of green development. All of this has laid a strong foundation for green development education. Carrying out green development education is not only a concrete practice for implementing the concept of green development, but also an important lever for contributing Chinese wisdom and experience.

Compared with the rest of the country, Jiangxi began earlier in educating people in the concept of green development. Building a "Jiangxi model" of green development education is not only feasible but can also lay an even firmer foundation for creating a "Jiangxi model" for a Beautiful China and further enrich the meaning of that model. First, making the province strong through ecology and developing through green growth has long been one of Jiangxi's most consistent development strategies and greatest advantages. It is precisely under the guidance of the idea that "lucid waters and lush mountains are invaluable assets" and the guideline of "innovation-led development, reform breakthroughs, greater openness, green development, practical responsibility, and prosperous development for the people" that Jiangxi has grown into a national pilot zone for ecological civilization and become an ideal place for building a "Jiangxi model" for a Beautiful China. To maintain this advantage, Jiangxi needs the support of green development education. Second, it is both the country's earnest expectation for Jiangxi and the natural requirement that Jiangxi serve as a model and strive to be a pioneer. Only three years after his previous inspection, General Secretary Xi Jinping again visited Jiangxi for inspection and guidance, further making clear that Jiangxi should accelerate the building of an ecological-civilization system and pursue high-quality development to create a "Jiangxi model" for a Beautiful China and paint a new picture of reform and development in Jiangxi in the new era. It should therefore be Jiangxi's responsibility to advance education reform, integrate green development education into the education system, and take the lead nationwide in this area. Third, the experience Jiangxi has already accumulated in green development education has laid a foundation for building a "Jiangxi model" of green development education. Although the province has not yet established a dedicated education

system oriented toward green development, it has accumulated years of experience in implementing ESD, and seven batches of schools have successively received the title of “Green School” jointly awarded by the Department of Education of Jiangxi Province and the provincial department of ecology and environment.

Jiangxi possesses the preconditions for pioneering green development education. The key question is how to build a “Jiangxi model” of green development education. As noted above, China has already begun practical exploration in this area, but the work is still at an early stage and needs to learn from the experience of developed Western countries. Yet because the term “green development” originated in China, the closest concept used in Western countries is sustainable development, and those countries have achieved great success in education for sustainable development. Finland has been at the global forefront in ESD and can provide Jiangxi with valuable experience and lessons. Finland covers 338,000 square kilometers, with forest coverage as high as 68 percent, earning it the reputation of a “green treasury”; inland waters account for 10 percent of its territory, giving it the title “land of a thousand lakes.” Benefiting from its sound ecological environment and the success of its ESD efforts, Finland has been rated one of the world’s most competitive countries and has reached global leading levels in such fields as energy, telecommunications, biotechnology, and environmental protection. OECD data and related studies show that Finland ranks first among OECD countries in educational efficiency. Finnish 15-year-old students have also performed outstandingly over successive cycles of the Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) in mathematics, reading, and scientific literacy, with scientific literacy in particular ranking among the world’s top five. Like Finland, Jiangxi’s greatest advantages and potential also lie in its ecological environment. If Jiangxi learns from Finland and devotes sustained effort to building a “Jiangxi model” of green development education, it can not only consolidate the foundation for green development but may also become a model for the whole country to learn from and help the Chinese concept of “green development,” as a form of Chinese wisdom and experience, play an even stronger leading role in the world.

## 1. The Historical Evolution of Finland's Philosophy of Education for Sustainable Development

Finland’s philosophy of education for sustainable development grew out of environmental education and was progressively refined as the international concept of sustainable development deepened. As early as the 1980s, Finland began incorporating environmental education into school curricula, using methods such as nature excursions, games, outdoor

activities, and inquiry-based learning. In 1985, Finland included environmental education in its national core curriculum and integrated it, as an interdisciplinary theme, into such courses as consumer education, traffic education, and health education. In 1992, Finland implemented its national strategy for environmental education, establishing the importance of environmental education within the Finnish education system and incorporating it into maternal and child health care, day care, and the education system. Thereafter, amid the global wave of sustainable development, Finland promoted a shift from environmental education to education for sustainable development, broadening the content from a sole focus on the environment to encompass the ecological, social, cultural, and economic dimensions of sustainable development.

In 1992, the United Nations Conference on Environment and Development was convened in Rio de Janeiro, adopting Agenda 21, and launching a global action plan for sustainable development. In 1993, European university leaders proposed the Copernicus Charter, explicitly stating that universities bear responsibility for promoting environmental civilization and advancing the practice of environmental ethics. In 1996, the Baltic region responded actively by issuing the Baltic 21E Programme. In 1997, UNESCO explicitly advanced the concept of “education for sustainability.” Against this background, Finland established its National Commission on Sustainable Development in 1993, introduced a Finnish action plan for sustainable development in 1995, and formally established a national program for sustainable development in 1998. This process led Finland, from the 1990s onward, to expand environmental education so that it also covered the ecological, economic, social, and cultural dimensions of sustainable development. Since 1999, Finland’s Ministry of Education has issued a five-year education and research development plan every four years, incorporating sustainable development into education and research. In 2002, the Finnish Ministry of Education signed the Baltic 21E Programme, aiming to make ESD a natural and permanent component of the education system and thereby formally establishing its importance throughout Finland’s entire education system. In 2003, the United Nations adopted the proposal for the United Nations Decade of Education for Sustainable Development (2005-2014), which was formally approved in 2005. On this basis, Finland began drafting its Framework for Education for Sustainable Development in 2003 and in 2006 issued its Ten-Year Plan for Education for Sustainable Development, which covered implementation strategies and action recommendations for ESD in general education, adult education, technical education, university education, and research and development institutions. In the revised national core

curriculum for the new millennium, sustainable development was integrated into teaching across the entire education system.

## 2. Finland's Practices and Outcomes in Education for Sustainable Development

### 2.1 The State Establishes a Clear Basic Framework for ESD, Emphasizes Interdepartmental Cooperation, and Conducts Performance Evaluation

The Finnish government has written sustainable development into laws and other fundamental provisions, incorporated the entire population into ESD, and made clear the responsibilities and general requirements of schools at all levels in this field. It places particular emphasis on the importance of cooperation between the education sector and other sectors in advancing sustainable development. The Ministry of Social Affairs and Health is required to help build a socially strong and economically sustainable society; public-administration departments are required to ensure that people enjoy a healthy environment and have opportunities to participate in environmental decision-making; the Ministry of the Environment is required to promote sustainable development; and localities, in accordance with the Local Government Act, are required to work to improve residents' welfare and the sustainable development of each region, including by disseminating information, education, and training related to local sustainable development. Finland's National Board of Education and Ministry of the Environment, for example, jointly developed an online service on sustainable development, effectively creating a virtual school for sustainable development to disseminate materials on sustainable lifestyles to schools, stakeholder groups, and the public. To encourage schools to promote ESD, Finland established an environmental certification scheme covering teaching, building maintenance, transportation, materials use, school cafeterias, safety management, and related areas, and awards certificates to schools that make serious efforts to implement ESD. For universities and colleges, Finland signs a "performance agreement" every three years that includes indicators for advancing the effectiveness of ESD and then carries out follow-up performance evaluations.

### 2.2 Preschool Education, Guided by Equality and Joy, Relies Mainly on Extracurricular Practice to Foster Young Children's Initial Awareness of Sustainable Development

Finland's ESD begins in preschool and follows the basic principles of equality and joy. Natural science is treated as a key module in preschool education and is combined with other

core areas such as mathematics, language and communication, physical activity, and health to initiate children's awareness of sustainable development. Drawing on its national conditions of nearly 69 percent forest coverage and its identity as the "land of a thousand lakes," Finland has established forest kindergartens, using forests as classrooms and natural surroundings, weather, plants and animals, and natural phenomena as course content. Art, physical activity, and mathematics classes may all be taught in the forest. Some kindergartens also create small ecological gardens so that children can learn through enjoyment. These practices encourage children to take an interest in nature, observe natural phenomena, acquire basic knowledge about greenery and environmental protection, and become aware that their own actions affect nature. They also integrate nature with aesthetics, health, mathematics, and other fields, while strengthening young children's physical fitness as they develop an initial understanding of sustainable development.

### 2.3 Primary and Secondary Education Centers on the Capacity to Perceive Changes in Human and Environmental Health and Uses Multiple Measures to Encourage Students to Think About How to Practice Sustainable Development in Daily Life

At the primary and secondary levels, Finland's ESD is organized mainly around cultivating students' ability to perceive changes in human and environmental health. For pupils aged 7 to 16 in primary and lower secondary education, the educational theme is responsibility for the environment, well-being, and a sustainable future; for students aged 16 to 18 in upper secondary education, the educational theme is the practice and action of sustainable development. In curriculum design, sustainable-development content appears most prominently in natural-science education, but it is also linked with home economics, arts and crafts, and humanities and language courses. Geography classes, for example, encourage students to pay attention to natural landscapes in everyday life; art classes introduce local natural and human landscapes; and social-studies courses incorporate such matters as the use and management of water and electricity on campus. The purpose is to make students aware of the importance of protecting the environment and conserving resources and, more importantly, to cultivate a responsible way of life.

At the same time, Finland actively cooperates with organizations outside schools to run nature schools. Finland has many organizations dedicated to environmental issues and nature activities, and these organizations generally maintain divisions for children and young people. By working with such organizations to plan short courses, projects, special theme days,

competitions, working groups, and sustainable development camps, schools cultivate students' awareness and perceptual ability regarding sustainable development. Finland also has more than 30 nature schools, usually affiliated with a primary or lower secondary school, that focus on cultivating sustainable lifestyles and a sense of environmental responsibility, helping students understand that human beings are an integral part of nature. According to the results of an external evaluation conducted in 2012 on behalf of Finland's Ministry of Education and Ministry of the Environment, 35 percent of the 917 primary and secondary schools surveyed had developed their own sustainable development programs and plans.

## 2.4 Vocational Education Takes the Cultivation of Application-Oriented Talent for Sustainable Development as Its Core and Uses School-Enterprise Cooperation to Prepare Students for Sustainable Practice in Future Work

Finland's vocational-education framework clearly requires students to establish the ecological, economic, social, and cultural principles of sustainable development and to comply with core laws, regulations, and agreements related to sustainable development. The concept of sustainable development is required to be integrated into all 52 higher vocational certificates, covering 120 different specializations, and is embedded in interdisciplinary study, curricula, and school-enterprise cooperation to raise students' awareness of sustainable development in their future work. In curriculum design, both required courses such as physics, chemistry, health, arts, and culture and elective courses such as environmental knowledge, ethics, and entrepreneurship must contain sustainable-development content. Vocational institutions also offer elective courses on circular economy, energy conservation and emissions reduction, green lifestyles, and the use of new energy, including opportunities for students to participate in plans related to energy use and conservation in electricity, water, transportation, and similar areas during daily teaching and other activities. Since 2006, Finland has further required that practical examinations in vocational education include knowledge points related to sustainable development.

The greatest highlight of Finland's vocational education is school-enterprise cooperation. This cooperation covers a wide range of fields, including real estate, social welfare and health, metalworking and engineering, environmental sanitation, and cleaning services. Many ESD projects are supported by off-campus funding. One example is the Aikuis-KEKE project carried out in 2011-2012, which was funded by Finland's National Board of Education and Hyria Education Ltd. and aimed to integrate the concept of sustainable development into adult vocational education.



## 2.5 Higher Education Embeds Sustainable Development in Teaching, Teacher Training, and Research in Order to Better Serve Academic Development and Local Sustainable Development

Since 1996, Finland's Ministry of Education has required all universities to incorporate sustainable-development content into education. Over time, Finland's higher-education ESD efforts have come to be reflected mainly in curriculum development, teacher training, and research activity, with the aim of strengthening students' awareness of sustainable development, improving teachers' capacity to teach ESD, and enhancing research capability in the field of sustainable development to better serve both disciplinary development in higher education and local sustainable development. Universities, according to their own needs and capacities, have introduced different courses, projects, and plans covering such themes as energy, consumption, waste treatment, commuting, and broader human, social, and technological topics. Teacher-training courses likewise include ESD content, and the training process has generated a large body of ESD teaching materials and pedagogical methods. Scientific research on sustainable development has also shifted from an initial focus on the ecological effects of emissions and waste toward broader attention to environmental and sustainable-development issues, while also connecting with enterprises to address concrete sustainability challenges faced in business development. Of the 26 centres of excellence partially funded by the Academy of Finland during 2000-2005, 7 studied environmental and sustainable-development issues; during 2014-2019, many of the themes pursued by 14 centres of excellence concerned sustainable development.

Benefiting from the success of its ESD efforts, Finland has seen marked improvements in the sustainability of its economy, society, and ecology. According to World Bank data, against a backdrop of sluggish global economic recovery, Finland's GDP growth rate reached 2.13 percent in 2016 and 2.63 percent in 2017, exceeding the corresponding European Union levels of 1.96 percent and 2.44 percent and ranking 18th and 19th respectively among EU member states. According to Eurostat, Finland's goods exports, led by electromechanical products, pulp and paper, base metals and related products, and transport equipment, grew by as much as 17.9 percent in 2017. Alongside this economic recovery, Finland's energy-consumption structure and environmental conditions improved markedly. Eurostat data show that in 2016 renewable energy accounted for 39 percent of Finland's total energy consumption, nearly 10 percentage points higher than in 2004. Data from the Finnish Environment Institute further show that by 2018 the ecological status of 85 percent of Finland's lakes and 65 percent of its rivers had been

assessed as excellent or good; by 2015 airborne nitrogen emissions had fallen to less than half their 1990 level, sulfur emissions to one-sixth of their 1990 level, and emissions of most heavy metals and organic compounds had also declined significantly.

### 3. Insights from Finland's Experience for Green Development

#### Education in Jiangxi

Education is the cornerstone of social and economic development. It is the primary driving force for establishing the concept of green development and for transforming social ideals into practical action. Jiangxi's green development requires the participation of society as a whole and requires education to cultivate the values, modes of behavior, and ways of life needed for that rise. Drawing on Finland's experience and considering the requirements of Jiangxi's green development, the province should build based on its existing framework for ESD, a system of green development education centered on preschool education, primary and secondary education, vocational education, and higher education, with clearly defined responsibilities, distinct levels, and strong articulation among the different stages. In this way, Jiangxi can create a "Jiangxi model" of green development education and provide experience and lessons for the country in pioneering green development education.

#### 3.1 Formulate a Plan for Green Development Education in Jiangxi and Establish a Green Development Education System

Jiangxi should take planning as the guiding priority. Based on the National Outline for Medium- and Long-Term Education Reform and Development (2010-2020), and considering its position as a national pilot zone for ecological civilization and the requirements of green development, the province should formulate a plan and detailed implementation rules for green development education in Jiangxi and construct a corresponding education system:

1. It should make clear the necessity of green development education for the education system as a whole and incorporate green development into the overall curriculum framework and training plans.
2. It should define the overall requirements and action plan for green development education, including guiding principles, basic principles, development goals, main tasks, and safeguard measures.
3. It should clarify the responsibilities of all departments in green development education to ensure that interdepartmental cooperation promotes smooth implementation.
4. It should spell out the tasks of preschool education, primary and secondary education, vocational education, and higher education in green development education, including

the basic principles that schools at all levels should follow in setting up theoretical frameworks, arranging curricula, organizing campus activities, and conducting performance evaluation.

### 3.2 Advance Green Development Education from Early Childhood and Initiate Preschool Children's Awareness of Green Development

Jiangxi should likewise begin green development education in early childhood by explicitly incorporating it into preschool education, guiding the work by the goal of stimulating children's interest, and enabling them from an early age to learn to understand and appreciate nature and the environment and to become aware that their behavior affects the surrounding environment. In this way, the seeds of a green development concept can be planted in preschool children:

1. In a learn-through-play format, green development content should be embedded within existing preschool themes such as people and the environment, or integrated into art, mathematics, physical activity, and other courses by using plants, animals, and natural phenomena as examples.
2. Kindergartens with the necessary conditions should be encouraged to establish small ecological gardens, allowing children to construct a miniature circulating biosphere and thereby develop a deeper understanding of nature and the environment. For example, children can be made responsible for feeding fish, thus cultivating a sense of responsibility, and learning about the characteristics and habits of fish; use fish waste as fertilizer for plants or vegetables, thereby understanding relevant knowledge about plants and vegetables; and, through cooked fish and vegetables, strengthen taste experience and learn basic knowledge about the food chain.
3. Green kindergarten brands should be cultivated and promoted. Kindergartens should be encouraged both to capitalize on their own strengths in curricula and training content to develop distinctive forms of green education, and to use environmentally friendly and natural materials in their physical facilities, adapting to local conditions in shaping the kindergarten environment. They may, for instance, use natural changes in terrain to construct slides and climbing slopes, or use the light entering through skylights and the view of the sky to help children experience the seasons, climate, the sky, and the universe.

### 3.3 Popularize Green Development Education at the Primary and Secondary Levels so That the Concept Takes Root Among Young People

Jiangxi should take quality-oriented education as its core and comprehensively popularize green development education at the primary and secondary levels so that the concept of green development takes root among young people:

1. It should break down disciplinary barriers and strengthen foundational course design around the concept of green development. In addition to setting green development themes in traditional subjects such as natural science, the province should integrate the concept into geography, art, social studies, and other courses to combine disciplinary knowledge with the idea of green development.
2. It should add modules on green development education to the design of integrated practical-activity courses. From primary through secondary education, course design should progress from easy to difficult: from getting to know nature, to protecting nature, to gaining an in-depth understanding of the real-world application of green development. At the primary level, students may focus on identifying the types of plants and animals in their hometowns and investigating the local situation of plants, animals, natural resources, and waste sorting. At the secondary level, students may focus more on the prevention and treatment of local environmental problems.
3. It should implement campus activities related to green development. Schools may organize activities around themes such as “The Earth Is My Home” and “Green Travel,” establish exhibition rooms devoted to recycling, and encourage students to participate in the management of water and electricity use at school.

### 3.4 Vigorously Promote Vocational Education for Green Development and Cultivate Application-Oriented Talent Suited to Green Development

Guided by the goal of cultivating application-oriented talent that can connect effectively with enterprises, Jiangxi should vigorously promote vocational education for green development and build a vocational training system centered on green-development capability:

1. It should add elective modules on green development to vocational education, integrate the concept of green development into the vocational curriculum system, and require students to complete at least one credit in this area.
2. On the principle of aligning course content with occupational standards, vocational institutions should offer green development courses suited to local conditions. For example, fashion-design majors can add content on the use of environmentally friendly

materials and recyclability, while mechanical-manufacturing majors can add content on energy conservation, emissions reduction, and environmental protection.

3. It should establish innovative school-enterprise cooperation platforms and strive to secure enterprise funding for green development education. Through school-enterprise cooperation, schools can both provide talent training for enterprises to raise the green-development awareness of their current employees and deliver technical personnel whose professional skills are matched to enterprise posts and who possess concepts of cleaner production, recycling, energy conservation, and environmental protection, thereby meeting enterprises' needs for practice-oriented talent and for green development.

### 3.5 Fully Advance Higher Education for Green Development and Serve the New Needs of Jiangxi's Green Rise

Taking equal emphasis on green development education and scientific research as its core, Jiangxi should fully advance higher education for green development and jointly promote innovation in this field to serve the new needs of Jiangxi's green development:

1. It should strengthen the construction of green-development courses and teaching materials in higher education, as well as teacher training. Every higher-education institution should offer at least one required course on green development and, where conditions permit, provide a package of green-development electives to enhance graduates' awareness of green development. Universities should be encouraged to compile green-development teaching materials with local characteristics for schools at different levels, such as materials focused on the animals, plants, or natural environment of the Poyang Lake basin. Through teacher-education programs and in-service training, universities should also be encouraged to improve the capacity and level of grassroots teachers engaged in green development education.
2. Led by well-known universities in the province and in collaboration with other higher-education institutions as well as departments concerned with education, environmental protection, and culture, Jiangxi should establish a Provincial Green Development Center, build a provincial online platform for green development and an information-sharing platform for green education development, and provide services such as library resources, online information resources, the latest developments in green-development research, seminars, and themed activity days. These platforms should collect and share

proven experience and organize and promote exchanges among government, universities, and enterprises.

3. It should support universities in carrying out research on green development to provide analytical support for Jiangxi's green development. University teachers and students should be encouraged to apply actively for research projects related to green development, and universities should be encouraged to connect and cooperate with enterprises to resolve concrete environmental problems faced in business development, provide enterprises with pathways to green development, and better serve Jiangxi's green development.

#### **Author Sign-Offs.**

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